

# First farmers

For almost all of human prehistory (the time before written records), humans lived as hunter-gatherers, depending on wild foods for survival. But a new way of life began around 10,000 BCE, when people in western Asia started to grow crops—and later, tame wild animals—in a process known as domestication. Humans had become farmers.

*Wild einkorn was domesticated to produce bigger grains.*

Farming changed everything about human life. It was much harder work than gathering food, and it led to a more limited diet. Yet it produced much more food, which could be stored for future use, resulting in population growth. To be near their crops, people settled in villages, which in time grew into towns. Farming required advanced tools to be made—this was the beginning of the Neolithic Age (New Stone Age).

Rather than everyone working in the fields, some people could now specialize in craftwork, such as weaving and pottery.

Farmers needed to know when to plant their crops, so they kept a close track of the seasons using the sun and the stars. This led to new religious beliefs, in which people honored the sun, Earth, and human ancestors, who were thought to watch over the living.

Farming began separately in different parts of the world, each of which developed different crops. While farmers in East Asia grew rice and millet, people in Central America grew maize and beans.

## ◀ DOMESTICATING PLANTS

*The most important plants domesticated by early farmers were grasslike grain crops, which could be adapted to produce more food and harvested in bulk. Wild einkorn and emmer, two types of wheat, were the first to be domesticated in a region of the Middle East known as the Fertile Crescent. Around 7000 BCE, farmers in modern-day Mexico transformed another grain, the wild teosinte plant, into maize.*

*An ear of teosinte has far fewer kernels than modern maize.*

*Figs were some of the first fruits to be domesticated.*

WILD EINKORN

TEOSINTE

WILD EMMER

FIGS